pivotal to the making of these shows, and the budgets are big, since locales, sets and costumes have to be authentic. The challenge is to imagine how these national icons would speak and behave; there is only so much creative licence you can take without the risk of offending public sentiment. Still, Advani found a way to make *Revolutionaries* different from *Freedom at Midnight*. "I'm treating it like *Gangs of Wasseypur* meets *Inglourious Basterds*," he says, as he focuses on youth like Kartar Singh Sarabha and Ras Behari Bose, who revolted against the British Raj. "The idea is to have fun with history." And also to expose the younger generation to figures beyond the ones in school textbooks or popular cinema. Think Bhagat Singh, Mangal Pandey, Udham Singh or Jhansi ki Rani.



"*Kesari 2* is important because the empire went into overdrive after Jallianwala Bagh to laud General Dyer as a hero"

KARAN SINGH TYAGI
Filmmaker

KESARI CHAPTER 2 (2025)



For others, delving into the past is more than just reviving forgotten heroes or recounting colonial atrocities. *The Waking of a Nation*, says Madhvani, was also a way to examine how racism and prejudice were fundamental to the British colonising project. "The idea that you cannot actually rule yourself... how did we believe that and let it happen?" asks Madhvani. "We got brainwashed." Given an opportunity, Madhvani would continue *The Waking of a Nation* series by looking at another defining moment in India's freedom struggle—the Revolt of 1857. He is particularly interested in the Peel Commission that was appointed to investigate the mutiny.

Shedding light on lesser-known heroes was also the impulse behind *Kesari Chapter 2*, Karan Singh Tyagi's directorial debut. A student of law and politics, Tyagi was deeply moved by *The Case that Shook the Empire*, a book by C. Sankaran Nair's great-grandson Raghu Palat and his wife Pushpa. "Sankaran Nair was knighted by the British Empire and resigned from the council [after the Jallianwala Bagh tragedy]," Tyagi said in a statement to the press. "For him to then take on the British in the most dramatic of ways is a story of valour." Among the triggers, Tyagi said, was watching a documentary by General Dyer's great-granddaughter, in which she defends his actions and calls the assembled gathering "looters". "That interview really angered me," Tyagi said. "*Kesari 2* is important because you'll be shocked to know that the empire went into overdrive after the massacre, going to extreme lengths in order to laud General Dyer as a hero."

Feature films set in the colonial era have been made before. But they have either been biopics or entertaining spectacles like *Lagaan* or *RRR*. When it comes to Gandhi, it's still the Richard Attenborough production, a predominantly English-language feature, which remains the reference point. Will Hansal Mehta and Applause Entertainment's *Gandhi* change that and finally give Indian audiences a local story celebrating their greatest leader?

"The world needs Gandhi now more than any other time," Pratik Gandhi had told INDIA TODAY last year while shooting the show. "We have taken him for granted and there's a generation that's understanding him very weirdly and differently. It is very easy to criticise him. The beautiful thing is Gandhi let people judge him. He had the guts to reveal his flaws and mistakes." The film aims to tell the story of the man that was Gandhi, more than the Mahatma.

And even as Advani embarks on the "crazy adventure" that is *Revolutionaries*, which follows the youngsters who were part of the Ghadar movement, he clarifies that it wasn't a calculated move to become a genre specialist. He admits that these are time-consuming exercises and carry tremendous responsibility, but he wouldn't have it any other way. "I like to tell stories of nation-building and non-jingoistic patriotism," he says. It is a worthy endeavour. ■